Said Concept Artist Charlie Wen, “Since my first priority on the film was to come up with the look of Hydra, it made sense to begin with the most recognizable element, Red Skull. When I first joined Captain America, Ryan had already done several iconic Red Skull head designs that kept the traditional appeal from the comics. I wanted to show other possibilities for his head that we could explore, from the more alien to a deformed look. Both directions strayed a bit too far from the iconic Red Skull of the comics, so we eventually went back to the more traditional look of his head.

“Some of these earlier Red Skull designs had a more operatic feel to them — a bit of pomp and circumstance, more focus on mixing different materials and textures — while the latter and final designs had less focus on larger textural changes and more emphasis on cleaner, more methodical lines and shapes with smaller textural shifts.”